

Zoho CRM covers the entire gambit of functionality for the CRM space but is strongest in Sales Force Automation. One benefit with a product like this is that you get your sales team to adopt best practices in managing the sales pipeline. You can track a potential customer from the moment you are able to initiate contact with the individual or organisation representative, right through to quotation submission and winning (or losing) the order. Zoho suggests stages in the sales pipeline that you can use or modify according to your specific industry requirements. After-sales support is managed through the Cases and Solutions feature, which essentially generates a support ticket for each complaint and enables customers to submit their requests directly via a Web form, or indirectly over the phone and through other, traditional channels.

Marketing management, which relates to your advertising and promotional campaigns, is also supported, and you can link your sales activities to specific campaigns. This will help you identify the campaigns that are most effective and allow you to fine-tune your marketing strategy.

A barebones inventory management system helps you keep track of your stock, and manage your product catalogue and purchases. If you have an extensive list of products, you can create a product catalogue of your product range and have price books unique to each customer. This is a frequent requirement when selling the same product at different prices to many customers.. You can also manage your purchases by maintaining a database of your suppliers (vendors) and issuing purchase orders for your various purchases. However, this is at best a stop-gap. If you have inventory of substantial value, it is better you consider a full-fledged order processing and inventory system that can give you greater control in managing your stock movement.

We've barely scratched the surface of all you can do with this application, but suffice it to say that if you're looking for a cost-effective customer relationship management application, Zoho is